AI Spend Intelligence: Market Analysis

Oct 9, 2026 · @Marc

Executive summary

The need is real and growing fast, but the basic product, a dashboard of AI token spend by employee and by use, is already free or bundled. The opportunity is a narrower wedge: AI cost attribution by client and matter for mid-market professional services firms.

- **Market.** Metered business AI spend runs roughly $60B to $100B a year in 2026. Software to monitor it is a $1.1B market on a monitoring fee alone, and about $3.8B with gain-share, procurement and enterprise revenue.
- **Who pays by the token.** An estimated 180,000 to 245,000 US firms with 20 or more employees carry metered AI spend.
- **Competition.** Ramp offers token spend management free. Rippling bundles an AI Spend Console. Anthropic and OpenAI shipped per-user analytics and caps in mid-2026. Vantage and other FinOps tools cover engineering teams.
- **Gap.** Nobody attributes AI spend to clients, matters or workflows, joins SaaS AI credits with model spend, or manages AI commitments.
- **Target tier.** Professional services firms with 50 to 1,000 employees, sold to the CFO. Serviceable market is $240M to $900M, with $6M to $20M of ARR reachable in three years depending on the revenue model.
- **Value.** Cut waste, recover or price in client costs, and close the books faster. At a 1.5% fee, removing 10% of waste returns about 6.7x the price.

Verdict. Do not build a general AI spend dashboard; that race is lost to free and bundled tools. Build the client-level wedge only if CFO interviews confirm firms will act on the data. Otherwise it is a feature an incumbent ships next quarter.

Market context

Usage-based AI is now the fastest-growing cost line in many companies, and most finance teams cannot see who or what drives it. Spend is moving from flat seats to metered tokens, credits and agent actions, which makes bills volatile and hard to allocate.

Signal	Figure	Source
Worldwide spend on generative AI models, 2026	$28.3B, up 117% from $13B in 2025	Gartner via Techstrong
Worldwide spend on AI models and platforms, 2026	$64B, up 63% from $39B in 2025	Gartner via IT Brief
US enterprise generative AI spend, 2025	$37B, up from $11.5B in 2024	Menlo Ventures via Quash

Signal	Figure	Source
Anthropic annualized revenue, end of July 2026	Over $65B, up from about $9B at end of 2025	Reuters
OpenAI annualized revenue, mid-2026	About $40B	Free Press Journal, citing Bloomberg
FinOps teams managing AI spend	98% in 2026, up from 63% in 2025 and 31% in 2024	FinOps Foundation via USU

Why it hurts. Coding agents turned per-seat tools into metered spend. Uber exhausted its 2026 AI coding budget in four months, at $500 to $2,000 per engineer per month (TechStackups). Rippling found its token bill heading toward 40% of R&D headcount budget, with 10 to 15% of employees driving about 60% of spend (TechCrunch via AI Weekly).

Nobody owns it. In a Harness survey of 700 practitioners, 52% had no clear AI cost owner and respondents estimated 26% of AI spend is wasted (Harness). FinOps teams rank visibility as their top AI challenge, then allocation to business units, then ROI (Virtasant).

It is spreading beyond model APIs. Salesforce prices Agentforce at $0.10 per action through Flex Credits, and Microsoft charges $0.008 to $0.01 per Copilot Credit (DEV). Each SaaS vendor that adds metered AI creates another bill finance cannot attribute.

Who pays by the token

An estimated 350,000 to 535,000 US firms carry some metered AI spend today, and about 180,000 to 245,000 of them have 20 or more employees. That second group is the practical market for a paid monitoring product.

What the providers report. OpenAI counts more than 1 million business customers paying through ChatGPT for Work or its API (OpenAI via Longterm Wiki). Anthropic counts more than 300,000 business customers, and over 1,000 of them spend more than $1M a year (Sovereign Magazine). These are global and overlapping, and they include seat-only buyers.

What transaction data shows. In August 2026, 56.1% of the 70,000+ US businesses on Ramp paid for AI in the month. Finance and insurance firms were at 73.7% and information firms at 80.9% (Ramp AI Index on FRED). Ramp's sample skews toward tech-forward companies, and "paid for AI" includes flat seats, so metered spend is a subset.

Segment (US)	Firms	Paying for AI on Ramp, Aug 2026	Share with metered spend (our assumption)	Firms with metered spend (est.)	Typical metered spend per month
Enterprise, 500+ employees	about 20,000	59.0% (FRED)	70% to 80%	14,000 to 16,000	Six to seven figures; many

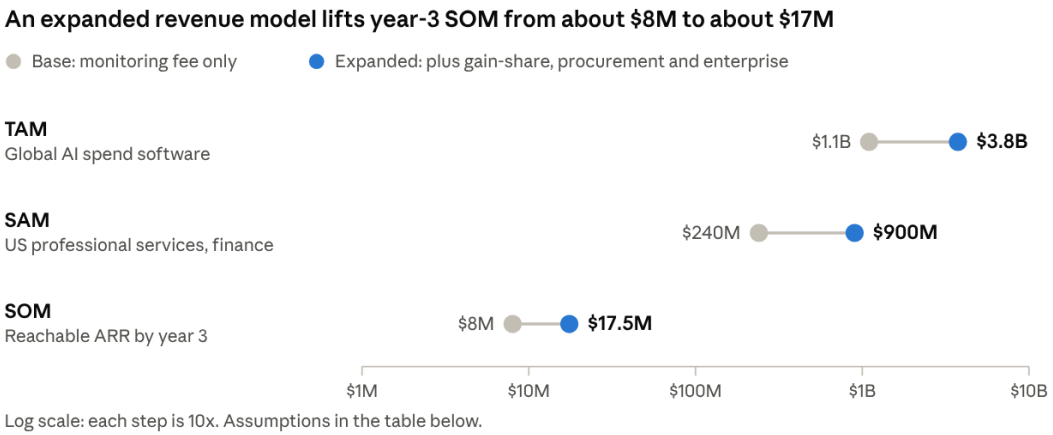
Segment (US)	Firms	Paying for AI on Ramp, Aug 2026	Share with metered spend (our assumption)	Firms with metered spend (est.)	Typical metered spend per month
					past $1M (Harness)
Mid-market, 20 to 499 employees	654,501	66.8% mid-size, 62.5% small (FRED)	25% to 35%	164,000 to 229,000	$5K to $100K (assumption)
Small, 1 to 19 employees	5,720,093	62.5% (FRED)	3% to 5%	170,000 to 290,000	Under $5K (assumption)

Firm counts are from Census 2022 data in the SBA 2025 US profile. The enterprise count is derived: firms under 500 employees are 99.7% of 6.4M employer firms.

Spend per head is the real driver, not headcount. The median engineer drew about $920 a month in billed AI coding spend in Larridin's data, and Uber ran $500 to $2,000 per engineer per month (Larridin; TechStackups). A 200-person company with 40 engineers can carry $35K or more a month in metered spend. Below roughly $5K a month, free tools are good enough and a paid product is hard to justify.

Market sizing: TAM, SAM, SOM

Metered business AI spend ran roughly $60B to $100B a year at mid-2026 and is heading toward $150B by year end. On a monitoring fee alone the software market is about $1.1B; adding gain-share, procurement and enterprise revenue lifts it to about $3.8B. Year-3 SOM is $6M to $9M on the base model and $15M to $20M on the expanded model.



Our estimates from the assumptions table below · annual software revenue, $M

Layer	Base	Expanded	Basis and what changes
Spend under management	$75B midpoint of $60B to $100B (July 2026 run rate)	About $150B	Base: Anthropic business revenue is about 80% of a $65B run rate (Reuters, Reuters); OpenAI runs about $40B. Expanded: year-end run rate, with Anthropic alone expected at $100B to $120B (Free Press Journal, citing FT), plus SaaS AI credits and agents, which Gartner puts at $29.2B in 2026 (Gartner)
Take rate	1.5% (range 1% to 2%)	2.5%	Base: Vantage charges about 1% of tracked spend (Vantage). Expanded adds about 1% from gain-share on savings and commissions on brokered AI commitments (our assumption)
TAM	$1.1B (range $0.6B to $2.0B)	About $3.8B	Spend x take rate
SAM	About $240M	About $900M	Base: 34,354 US professional services and finance firms with 20 to 499 employees x $7K (SBA, FRED). Expanded: $15K contracts with recovery and gain-share modules ($515M), plus about 3,900 enterprise firms in these sectors at $100K ($390M). Enterprise count is derived from SBA

Layer	Base	Expanded	Basis and what changes
			small-firm shares; contract sizes are our assumption
SOM, year 3	$6M to $9M	$15M to $20M	Base: 700 to 1,000 customers x $9K. Expanded: 800 mid-market at $15K ($12M), 25 enterprise at $100K ($2.5M), and $1M to $5M of procurement commissions

How far SOM can stretch. SOM is capped by how many customers a young team can sign in three years, not by market size. $50M of ARR by year 3 would take about 3,300 mid-market customers at $15K, or 500 enterprise contracts, against a free Ramp product. The credible way up is contract size, not logo count: recovery fees, gain-share, enterprise deals and procurement commissions.

The sources measure different things. Provider revenue includes seats, and Gartner's model category excludes most agent and app spend, so the spend range is wide. Firms with 500+ employees in these sectors are excluded from SAM and are upside.

The market is still compounding. Anthropic alone projects $190B to $200B of revenue in 2028, about 3x its July 2026 run rate (Reuters). If spend triples, the TAM roughly triples with it, to about $3B.

Competitive landscape

The core idea, token spend by employee and by type of use, already ships free from Ramp, bundled from Rippling, and natively from Anthropic and OpenAI as of mid-2026. A new entrant cannot win on the dashboard alone.

Player	Type	What it covers	Attribution	Controls	Price	Weak spot for us to exploit
Ramp AI Token Spend Management	Spend platform	Anthropic, OpenAI, Gemini, Cursor, OpenRouter	Provider, team, person, project, API key	Limits, anomaly alerts, weekly briefings, invoice reconciliation,	Free to start, customers or not	No client or matter view; no SaaS AI credits

Player	Type	What it covers	Attribution	Controls	Price	Weak spot for us to exploit
				cheaper-model tips		
Rippling AI Spend Console	HR plus spend	Anthropic, OpenAI Codex, Cursor, GitHub, HR data	Employee, team, role; spend vs pull requests	Gateway with routing and caps (waitlist)	Included in Rippling AI; 30-day trial	ROI is engineering-only; strongest inside Rippling
Claude Enterprise admin	Provider-native	Claude only	User and SCIM group; cost per commit	Per-user and group caps, 75% and 90% alerts, model entitlements	Included in Enterprise	One vendor; Team plan lacks group analytics (AI Codex)
ChatGPT Enterprise admin	Provider-native	ChatGPT and Codex credits	User, product, model	Workspace, group and individual caps	Included in Enterprise	One vendor
Vantage	FinOps	Cloud plus 30+ providers incl. OpenAI, Anthropic, Cursor	Developer, model, project	Budgets, anomaly alerts, token allocation	Free to $200/mo up to $20K tracked; Enterprise custom	Built for engineers and FinOps teams
CloudZero, Finout, nOps, Datadog	FinOps	Cloud plus OpenAI and Anthropic (CloudZero)	Feature, customer, business unit	Anomaly detection, unit costs	Enterprise contracts	Needs a FinOps team to run
Larridin	AI ROI	Subscriptions, APIs, coding tools; Workday, Okta,	Employee, team, project, department	Spend vs output insights	Raised $17M (CB Insights)	Output measures center on code

Player	Type	What it covers	Attribution	Controls	Price	Weak spot for us to exploit
		Google Workspace				
Gateways: Portkey, LiteLLM, Langfuse, Helicone, OpenRouter	Developer tooling	Any model routed through them	Per request, per key	Budgets, fallbacks, routing	Open source to enterprise	Must route all traffic; developer buyer
AWS Bedrock, Azure OpenAI	Hyperscaler-native	Own model catalogs	IAM principal or tag, daily grain	Cloud budgets	Free	No per-request cost; Azure needs a resource per team (Finout)

The category is consolidating fast. Ramp raised $750M at a $44B valuation in June 2026 and named token spend as a growth category (OTPP). In 2026, ClickHouse acquired Langfuse, Mintlify acquired Helicone, and Palo Alto Networks acquired Portkey (Infrabase). Independent point tools are being absorbed into spend, security and data platforms.

The providers' incentives cut both ways. Rippling's team said inference providers have no incentive to help customers control spend (TechCrunch). Yet Anthropic and OpenAI both shipped per-user caps in mid-2026, because runaway bills slow enterprise expansion. Expect native tooling to keep improving inside each vendor, but not across vendors.

Gaps in the market

Every current product attributes AI spend to people, teams, projects or API keys inside the company. The open space is attribution to the things that drive revenue and contracts: clients, matters, workflows and commitments.

Gap	Evidence	Covered today by	What to build
1. Client and matter attribution, with cost recovery	Law firm CFOs need token burn by practice group, matter and timekeeper (Learn Formula). Harvey token use rose 14x in six months (Artificial	Nobody; tools stop at employee, team, project or key	Tag every call to a client, matter or engagement; push totals into billing and practice systems as disbursements or pricing data

Gap	Evidence	Covered today by	What to build
	Lawyer). Legora moved its agent product to consumption billing in June 2026 (Radiant Law)		
2. Metered AI inside SaaS apps	Agentforce Flex Credits cost $0.10 per action, and Salesforce widened consumption pricing on Aug 31, 2026 (Let's Data Science). Analysts flag missing forecasting and governance tools for Flex Credits (Salesforce DevOps)	Each vendor's own wallet; Ramp covers five model providers	One ledger joining model APIs, coding tools and SaaS AI credits
3. Unit economics outside engineering	Rippling and Larridin tie spend to pull requests and code; Claude Code reports cost per commit	Engineering only	Cost per ticket resolved, contract reviewed or loan file processed; agents as cost owners
4. Person-level cost for cloud-billed models	Bedrock attribution is daily, with no per-request cost, and shared gateways need per-user credentials (eCorpIT). Azure needs a resource per team (Finout)	FinOps tools, at tag level	A light SDK or log ingest that stamps user, client and workflow on each call
5. Forecasting, commitments and procurement	Uber spent its full-year AI coding budget in four months. FinOps Foundation leaders hear of firms 3x over budget by April (Takara). Azure OpenAI draws down Microsoft commits; Bedrock counts toward AWS commits (Redress)	Alerts only (Ramp, providers)	Budget forecasts by team and client, commit burn-down, renewal benchmarks, negotiation support

Gap	Evidence	Covered today by	What to build
6. Regulated and privacy-sensitive buyers	Larridin's own FAQ fields "is this employee surveillance?" (Larridin). Need for metadata-only, private deployment is our hypothesis to validate	SaaS tools that need admin keys	Metadata-only collection, VPC deployment, audit-ready exports

Gaps 1, 2 and 5 are the strongest. Each serves a finance buyer, ties to revenue or contracts, and sits outside every competitor's current data model. Gaps 3 and 4 are features to add once the wedge lands.

Target customer and wedge

Start with mid-market professional services firms of 50 to 1,000 employees: law, accounting and advisory, consulting, agencies and managed service providers. They sell time and expertise to clients, so AI spend that cannot be tied to a client is a direct margin leak.

Segment	US firms, 20 to 499 employees	Pain signal	Coverage today	Role
Professional services	53,523	Matter-level token costs, client fee pressure	Nobody at client level	Primary wedge
Finance and insurance	15,185	73.7% pay for AI on Ramp; heavy security review	SaaS tools needing admin keys	Alternative wedge if the team has distribution there
Software and information	9,777	Highest spend per engineer	Ramp, Rippling, Vantage, providers	Avoid as beachhead; crowded
Enterprise, 500+ employees	about 20,000	Six to seven figures a month	FinOps platforms, providers	Expansion after proof

Firm counts are from the SBA 2025 US profile (Census 2022). Professional services covers all of NAICS 54, so the law, accounting and consulting subset is smaller.

Why professional services first. Some firms already treat AI token costs like eDiscovery hosting fees, a recoverable matter expense (Learn Formula). Others will absorb the cost, but they still need per-client cost data to price fixed-fee work. Either way the buyer needs a view no competitor offers. Ramp's 2026 move into serving accounting firms confirms the segment's value, and is also a warning (OTPP).

Buyer. The economic buyer is the CFO or COO; in law firms, the CFO and pricing director. The champion is the CIO or innovation lead who rolled out the AI tools. Daily users are practice leaders and the billing team.

Pricing angle. Ramp gives a basic view away, so the entry tier must be free or close to it. Vantage charges $200 a month for up to $20K of tracked spend, about 1% (Vantage). A workable model: free ingestion and dashboard below a spend threshold, then about 1% to 2% of spend under management, plus a gain-share option on documented savings or recovered costs. That implies a $6K to $30K annual contract in the mid-market (our assumption).

Motion. Lead with a free two-week AI spend audit that shows unattributed spend, cheaper-model savings and recoverable client costs. Resell through managed service providers and partner with practice management and billing vendors.

Expansion path. Add SaaS AI credits (gap 2), then forecasting and commit management (gap 5). Once you hold a firm's usage data, you can benchmark its rates and negotiate commitments on its behalf, much like an energy broker aggregates load. That turns a monitoring tool into a procurement business.

Value proposition

Positioning line: know what every AI dollar was for, which client it served, and whether it paid off. At a 1.5% fee, cutting 10% of waste returns several times the price before any client cost recovery.

Value levers, with evidence

- **Cut waste.** Practitioners estimate 26% of AI spend is wasted (Harness). Ramp says one in three customers has a cheaper model that does the same task, and AngelList found a $10K a month leak from missing prompt caching (SiliconANGLE).
- **Target the heavy users, not everyone.** At Rippling, 10 to 15% of employees drove about 60% of spend. Routing and limits took token spend from 40% to about 15% of headcount budget, and July costs were 37% of April's at similar volume (AI Weekly, citing TechCrunch).
- **Recover or price in client costs.** Per-matter cost data lets a firm bill AI as a disbursement or set fixed fees with real cost floors.
- **Close faster.** AI invoices rarely show what was consumed (SiliconANGLE), and nearly a third of teams need a full week to trace a cost spike (Harness).

Stakeholder	Problem today	What we deliver
CFO and finance	Volatile bills, no owner, invoices that do not reconcile to usage	One AI ledger across vendors, coded to cost centers and clients; forecasts and alerts before overruns
Firm leadership and pricing	AI cost invisible at the client level; fee pressure from clients	Cost per client and matter; recovery as a disbursement or input to fixed-fee pricing
CIO and IT	Native analytics are per vendor and often Enterprise-only	Cross-vendor caps, model defaults and policy in one place
Practice and team leads	No way to tell if spend produces output	Cost per unit of work, adoption by person, peer benchmarks

Illustrative ROI (assumptions, not data). A 300-person firm with $50K a month of metered AI spend pays about $9K a year at a 1.5% fee. Removing 10% of waste saves $60K a year, about 6.7x the fee. If the firm also recovers or prices in 20% of its client-attributable spend, that adds up to $120K a year.

Risks and open questions

The biggest risk is that a well-funded incumbent adds client tagging before the wedge is established. Speed into billing integrations is the main defense.

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation
Commoditization	Ramp's basic view is free; Rippling bundles it; Anthropic and OpenAI ship native caps	Own the client and matter data model and the billing integrations
Incumbent follows	Ramp has $750M of new capital and already serves accounting firms	Go deep on practice management and billing systems Ramp will not prioritize
Data access	Provider analytics APIs gate the data; Claude's Analytics API is Enterprise-only (AI Codex)	Offer an SDK, gateway and invoice ingestion as fallbacks
Client pushback on pass-through	Some legal leaders expect clients to resist itemized AI costs (Lawyers Weekly)	Sell pricing intelligence and margin protection, with recovery as an option
Price deflation	Per-token prices keep falling, though per-developer spend has risen 2x to 20x (Live in the Future)	Pair the spend-based fee with a platform fee
Privacy	Person-level tracking reads as surveillance	Metadata only; team-level views by default

Validate before building

- ☐ Interview 15 CFOs or COOs at law, accounting and consulting firms: recover AI costs, price them in, or absorb them?
- ☐ Confirm which practice management and billing systems accept AI cost lines by API
- ☐ Measure how much of a target firm's AI spend runs through tools with usable usage APIs (legal AI tools, Copilot, ChatGPT, Claude)
- ☐ Test willingness to pay against Ramp's free tier
- ☐ Check whether regulated buyers require private deployment before signing

Sources

Market and spend

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- Gartner AI models and platforms forecast, via IT Brief
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- Reuters: Anthropic revenue targets and business share
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- OpenAI: 1 million business customers, via Longterm Wiki
- Sovereign Magazine: Anthropic customer counts
- Ramp AI Index on FRED
- SBA Office of Advocacy 2025 US profile
- FinOps Foundation State of FinOps 2026, via USU and Virtasant
- Harness State of AI in FinOps 2026
- TechStackups: token spend per employee, Takara, Live in the Future

Competitors

- SiliconANGLE: Ramp token spend management and Ramp Series F
- Rippling AI Spend Console launch, TechCrunch, AI Weekly
- Anthropic: Claude Enterprise admin controls and AI Codex
- OpenAI ChatGPT Enterprise spend controls, via Let's Data Science
- Vantage pricing, CloudZero integration, Finout on cloud AI attribution
- Larridin launch, Larridin data, CB Insights
- Infrabase: LLM observability tools and acquisitions
- eCorpIT: Bedrock cost allocation, Redress: Bedrock vs Azure OpenAI
- DEV: Agentforce vs Copilot Studio pricing, Let's Data Science: Agentforce consumption, Salesforce DevOps

Professional services

- Learn Formula: token shock in law firms
- Artificial Lawyer: Harvey token use
- Radiant Law: legal has a token problem
- Lawyers Weekly: client reaction to AI pass-through